RESEARCH SUMMARY

2026 Agentic Coding Trends Report

How AI agents are changing the way software gets built — and what it means for everyone who works with technology.

Published by Anthropic · 2026 · Summary prepared by Intersection Strategies LLC

What This Is

Anthropic published a report identifying eight trends they believe will define how AI and software development intersect in 2026. It's based on research from their own teams, data from customers, and internal studies on how engineers actually work with AI today.

The short version: AI is no longer just a tool that helps developers write code faster. It's becoming a collaborator that handles entire workflows — and the implications stretch well beyond software.

> The core shift: Software development is moving from "writing code" to "orchestrating AI agents that write code." The humans who do this well will define what's possible. The ones who don't will find themselves competing with a different set of rules.

The Numbers That Matter

60%	27%	0-20%
of developer work now involves AI	of AI-assisted work is tasks that wouldn't have been done at all	of tasks engineers say they can "fully delegate" to AI

That last number is the most important one. Even with all this capability, engineers say they can hand off almost nothing completely. AI is a collaborator — not a replacement. The quality of that collaboration is what separates teams that move fast from teams that spin.

The 8 Trends

TREND 1 THE ENTIRE DEVELOPMENT PROCESS IS BEING REBUILT

The way software gets made is changing at a structural level — not just a speed level.

- Tasks that used to take weeks now take hours. Agents handle writing, testing, debugging, and documentation.

- Engineers are shifting from writing code to directing AI that writes code — deciding what to build and making sure it's right.
- New engineers can get up to speed on a codebase in hours instead of weeks, which changes how companies staff projects.

TREND 2 SINGLE AI AGENTS ARE BECOMING TEAMS OF AGENTS

Instead of one AI handling a task from start to finish, multiple specialized agents now work in parallel — each focused on a different part of the problem.

- One agent might handle screening. Another handles documentation. Another handles analysis. An orchestrating agent manages all of them.
- This lets organizations tackle complexity that a single AI session simply can't handle.
- The skill required: knowing how to break a big problem into pieces and assign each piece correctly.

Fountain	Used multi-agent orchestration to cut new fulfillment center staffing from 1+ weeks to under 72 hours. Achieved 50% faster screening and 2x candidate conversions.

TREND 3 AI CAN NOW WORK FOR DAYS, NOT JUST MINUTES

Early AI tools handled quick, single tasks. Now agents can work autonomously for hours or days, building entire applications with only occasional human checkpoints.

- Projects that weren't worth doing because of time cost are now viable.
- Years of accumulated technical debt can be worked through systematically.
- Entrepreneurs can go from idea to deployed product in days instead of months.

Rakuten	Claude Code completed a complex technical implementation in a 12.5 million line codebase in 7 hours of autonomous work. Achieved 99.9% accuracy.

TREND 4 HUMAN OVERSIGHT GETS SMARTER, NOT BIGGER

The best teams aren't reviewing everything AI produces. They're building systems that handle routine review automatically and only surface the things that actually need a human decision.

- AI reviews its own output at scale — checking for security issues, inconsistencies, and quality problems.
- Sophisticated agents flag situations where they're uncertain rather than pushing through and getting it wrong.
- The human role is shifting from reviewer to decision-maker for high-stakes moments.

> Important nuance from the research: Engineers delegate tasks they can easily verify or that are low-stakes. The more a task requires judgment, organizational context, or “taste” — the more humans stay involved. That boundary is shifting, but it hasn’t disappeared.

TREND 5 CODING IS NO LONGER JUST FOR DEVELOPERS

Agentic coding tools are expanding beyond professional engineers into almost every function of a business.

- Security teams, researchers, designers, operations, and legal teams are all using AI to build tools and automate workflows — without writing code.
- The gap between “people who code” and “people who don’t” is dissolving.
- Domain experts can now implement solutions to their own problems without waiting for an engineering ticket.

Anthropic Legal Team	A lawyer with no coding experience used Claude Code to build self-service tools that triage issues before they hit the legal queue. Cut review turnaround from 2-3 days to 24 hours.

TREND 6 PRODUCTIVITY IS GROWING THROUGH VOLUME, NOT JUST SPEED

AI isn’t just making existing work faster — it’s making previously impossible work happen.

- Engineers report a net decrease in time per task but a much larger increase in total output.
- 27% of AI-assisted work is tasks that simply wouldn’t have been done without AI — nice-to-have tools, experiments, minor fixes that always got deprioritized.
- Timeline compression changes which projects are even worth attempting.

TELUS	Over 13,000 custom AI solutions created internally. Engineering code shipped 30% faster. 500,000+ hours saved, averaging 40 minutes per AI interaction.

TREND 7 EVERY DEPARTMENT BECOMES A BUILDER

The report’s prediction: by end of 2026, the teams getting the most out of AI won’t be in engineering — they’ll be in sales, marketing, legal, operations, and finance.

- Non-technical teams gain the ability to automate their own workflows without filing tickets or waiting on developers.
- The bottleneck between “people who understand the problem” and “people who can build the solution” collapses.
- Experimental workflows that weren’t worth anyone’s time become trivial to try.

Zapier	89% AI adoption across the entire organization. 800+ AI agents deployed internally. Design teams prototype during live customer interviews in real-time.

TREND 8 THE SAME TOOLS THAT DEFEND ALSO ATTACK

Agentic coding makes it dramatically easier to build secure systems — and dramatically easier to attack them.

- Any engineer can now perform security reviews that used to require a specialist.
- Threat actors get the same capabilities. Attacks scale faster.
- The organizations that win build security into the architecture from day one, not as an afterthought.

The Honest Truth the Report Surfaces

Despite all the capability expansion, the research keeps landing on the same conclusion: AI works best when humans stay actively involved. The teams getting the best results aren't the ones handing everything off — they're the ones who've figured out exactly where human judgment still matters and focused their attention there.

> As one Anthropic engineer put it: "I'm primarily using AI in cases where I know what the answer should look like. I developed that ability by doing software engineering the hard way." The experience of knowing what "good" looks like doesn't go away. It becomes more valuable.

What This Means If You're Not a Developer

This report is written about software development. But the implications reach into every role in every organization:

- The people who understand their domain deeply and can clearly define what "good" looks like are becoming more valuable, not less.
- Waiting on a development team to build tools for your department is becoming unnecessary. The tools exist now.
- The gap between organizations that are actively building AI fluency and those that aren't is widening every month.
- AI handling 60% of work doesn't mean 60% of jobs disappear. It means the remaining 40% — judgment, direction, verification — becomes 100% of the job.

> The report’s closing argument: Organizations that treat agentic coding as a strategic priority in 2026 will define what’s possible. Those that treat it as an incremental productivity tool will discover they are competing in a game with new rules.

Bottom Line

In 2025, AI started handling parts of the software development process. In 2026, it’s handling entire workflows — and expanding beyond software into every department that has repetitive, structured work.

The people and organizations ahead of this aren’t moving faster at the same game. They’re playing a different one.

The window to get your bearings before this becomes table stakes is shorter than it looks.